

LARGER THAN LIFE (Left) A still from the trailer of Nitesh Tiwari's *Ramayana* and the poster of Prasanth Varma's *Jai Hanuman*

cast, it has already led to the announcement of a Mahavatar Cinematic Universe—six more films about the 10 avatars of Vishnu billed to "shake the soul of Bharat". Each is to be released at two-year intervals, and Kumar has already planned a tie-in film, about Ardhanareeshwar, a godly hybrid of Shiva and Parvati. Prasanth Varma, director of last year's *Hanu-Man*, too, has announced a cinematic universe, his next title based on Mahakali. Producer Vijay Subramaniam is releasing an AI-made micro-drama on Mahabharata this month and a feature on Hanuman in April.

What we are seeing is part of a "larger play, of how we have been becoming more accepting of our own roots, civilisational past and cultural heritage in the last decade or so", according to Ajit Andhare, producer of *Kurukshetra*, an upcoming Netflix animated show on the Mahabharata. "We have seen a surge of pride and what it has done is made us more confident of who we are."

EVERGREEN STORIES

Be that as it may, Hindu myths have also been popular entertainment in India for several decades. Vijay Bhatt's *Ram Rajya* (1943) remains the only film Gandhi ever saw. K.V. Reddy's *Mayabazar* (1957) was a landmark in Tamil and Telugu cinema, adapting the story of Vatsala's marriage to Abhimanyu, and inspiring the likes of S.S. Rajamouli. *Jai Santoshi Maa* (1975), about the titular Hindu goddess, brought droves to cinemas and outshone the likes of *Sholay* and *Deewaar* at the box office. Andhare himself cites shows like Ramanand Sagar's *Ramayana* (1987) and B.R. Chopra's *Mahabharata* (1988) as major influences, as well as the *Amar Chitra Katha* comics.

The recent *Adipurush* (2023) and *Hanu-Man* have been steps in the same direction. Perhaps what was needed for a resurgence of the genre was an unapologetically Hindu government at the Centre. Another reason could be advances in visual effects and animation technology, according to Tanya Bami, *Kurukshetra*'s series head at Netflix. "[The show] is an invitation for newer audiences to discover timeless themes through a format that feels fresh, contemporary and compelling," she says.

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> Producer, *Kurukshetra*

